

China First-Time Visitor Checklist

A practical pre-flight and arrival-day checklist for foreign visitors planning their first China trip.

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Use this before you fly, again when you land, and whenever a payment, train, hotel, or address detail feels uncertain.

Before you fly

- ☐ Confirm visa, visa-free transit, or entry eligibility for your passport and route.
- ☐ Save flights, hotels, train tickets, attraction bookings, and travel insurance offline.
- ☐ Keep passport name format consistent across bookings, payment apps, and train tickets.
- ☐ Screenshot your first hotel name, Chinese address, phone number, and nearest landmark.

Arrival day

- ☐ Set up mobile data before leaving the airport or railway station.
- ☐ Make one small Alipay or WeChat Pay test purchase before relying on mobile payment.
- ☐ Keep a small RMB cash backup for taxi, late arrival, or app verification problems.
- ☐ Do not schedule a non-refundable activity immediately after a long-haul arrival.

Payment

- ☐ Prepare Alipay as the main wallet and WeChat Pay as a backup if available.
- ☐ Add at least one international card and keep a backup card from another bank if possible.
- ☐ Carry a physical card for hotels, deposits, and premium merchants.
- ☐ Know both QR flows: scan the merchant code, or show your payment code to be scanned.

Apps

- ☐ Prepare payment, maps, translation, ride-hailing, and train support before landing.
- ☐ Download offline Chinese translation and keep camera translation available.
- ☐ Create a screenshot folder for passport copy, hotel, trains, flights, bookings, and insurance.

Internet

- [] Choose roaming, eSIM, SIM card, or pocket Wi-Fi before arrival.
- [] Keep the same phone usable for payment, maps, translation, tickets, and hotel contact.
- [] Save key information offline in case app login or mobile data fails at a station.

Hotel address

- [] Save the hotel name, Chinese address, phone number, and nearest metro or landmark.
- [] Show Chinese characters to taxi drivers and hotel staff instead of relying on English names.
- [] Confirm the hotel can register foreign passport holders before booking smaller properties.

Transport

- [] Check exact railway station names before booking: city names alone are not enough.
- [] Arrive 45-60 minutes early at large high-speed rail stations for passport checks and security.
- [] Screenshot train number, departure station, gate, carriage, seat, and arrival station.

Food

- [] Use camera translation for menus and keep short dietary phrases ready.
- [] Start with simple first-day meals near your hotel if you are jet-lagged.
- [] Try local specialties, but ask for less spicy or split broth when needed.

Packing

- [] Bring a power bank, adapter, comfortable shoes, tissues, basic medicine, and a small umbrella.
- [] Keep luggage light enough for station walks, metro transfers, escalators, and train boarding.
- [] Separate passport copy, backup card, and emergency cash from your main wallet.

Emergency phrases

Show the Chinese characters if pronunciation is difficult. Short written phrases are usually clearer than long translated paragraphs.

English	Chinese characters	Pinyin
Please help me.	请帮帮我。	Qing bang bang wo.
I need to go to the hospital.	我需要去医院。	Wo xu yao qu yi yuan.
Please call the police.	请帮我报警。	Qing bang wo bao jing.
Please take me to this address.	请带我去这个地址。	Qing dai wo qu zhe ge di zhi.
I do not understand.	我听不懂。	Wo ting bu dong.
Can I pay with Alipay?	可以用支付宝吗？	Ke yi yong Zhi Fu Bao ma?
Can I pay with WeChat Pay?	可以用微信支付吗？	Ke yi yong Wei Xin Zhi Fu ma?
I am allergic to this.	我对这个过敏。	Wo dui zhe ge guo min.
Less spicy, please.	请少辣。	Qing shao la.
Please write it down.	请写下来。	Qing xie xia lai.

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